

Promises and Pressure: The Disagreement

承诺与压力：分歧

Theme: 友谊、家庭与人际关系 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6,127

English Story

The disagreement began with a **slight**. “You did not **listen** to me,” Maya said. “You hear me, but you do not **listen**.” Lin was **certainly** tired, and he said something **foolish** about **supervision**. **Everybody** in the room went quiet. “**Hello?**” she said. “Is anybody there?”

She had a **distinctive** way of arguing: **firstly** the fact, then the feeling, then the request. “I **owe** you an apology,” he said, “and you **owe** me one.” She admired his honesty but not his timing. “That is **undoubtedly** true,” she said, “and **utterly** useless.”

The real subject was the shape of the work. She wanted a **mainstream** project with a proper structure; he wanted a **deliberate**, slow one. “You cannot **distinguish** the two any more,” she said. “One of us has to be the **beast**.” A **fisherman** on the television talked about tides, and the **sofa** was covered in papers.

They inspected the last three months like accountants. The **parenting** column, the letter from the **preacher**, a **witty idiom**, a **tasty** recipe: everything they had expended on pleasing other people. “This is a **scar**, not a strategy,” she said. “We are insuring a wreck. And the word for it is **attributive**: we keep describing, and never deciding.”

He was exhausted and, he admitted, **easily** distracted. “A **figurative** promise is worthless,” she said. “A **priceless** one costs something.” She spoke about **sightseeing** in an **underdeveloped** region and the way a town will **beautify** its front street while the back lanes flood. “A **lick** of paint is not a plan,” she said. Again and again he came back to one thing. “You are sure,” he said. “I am. Since March, **definitely**. And when I say it, I mean it **literally** — not as an **excellent** metaphor, not as a **superb** line, but as the plain fact that the work is ours.” “Any of it?” “All of it.” “Then it is **invaluable**,” he said, “and I will not lose it.” **Clearly**, one of them would have to **dominate** the schedule, though neither wanted to. An old man, a **fisherman** with a wooden boat, told them on the beach that a tide does not remain; whether you stay or go away is your own business, and the sea will never be more than the sea.

中文翻译

分歧始于一次轻慢。“你没有听我说话，”曼雅说，“你听见了，但你没有听。”林伟当然疲惫，他说了一句关于监督的蠢话。屋里所有人都安静下来。“喂？”她说，“有人在那儿吗？”

她争论的方式很有特色：先是事实，再是感受，最后是请求。“我欠你一个道歉，”他说，“你也欠我一个。”她钦佩他的诚实，但不欣赏他的时机。“那毫无疑问是真的，”她说，“而且完全没用。”

真正的问题在于工作的形态。她要一个结构合理的主流项目；他要一个深思熟虑、缓慢的项目。“你已经分不清这两者了，”她说，“我们中的一个必须当那头野兽。”电视里一位渔夫在讲潮水，沙发上铺满了纸。

他们像会计一样检查了过去三个月。育儿专栏、传道士的来信、一句诙谐的习语、一份可口的食谱：他们把一切都花在了取悦别人上。“这是伤疤，不是策略，”她说，“我们在给一艘沉船投保。而形容这件事的词是‘定语性的’：我们一直在描述，从不决定。”

他精疲力尽，而且他承认，很容易分心。“一个比喻式的承诺不值钱，”她说，“无价的承诺是要付出代价的。”她谈到在一个不发达地区的观光，以及一个城镇如何美化它的前街，而后巷却在淹水。“刷一层漆不是计划，”她说。他一次又一次回到同一件事上。“你确定吗？”他问。“我确定。从三月起，明确无疑。我说的时候是字面意思——不是一句出色的比喻，不是一句华丽的台词，而是一个朴素的事实：这份工作是我们的。”“全部吗？”“全部。”“那它就是无价的，”他说，“我不会丢掉它。”显然，他们中得有一个人来主导日程，虽然两人都不愿意。一位老人，一个划木船的渔夫，在海滩上告诉他们：潮水不会停留；你是留下还是离开是你自己的事，而海永远只是海。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
certainly 'sə:tenli POS: adv	adv. 确定地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r definitely or positively ('sure' is sometimes used informally for 'surely')
listen 'lɪsn POS: vi	vi. 听, 倾听, 听从; n. 听, 倾听 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. hear with intention; v. listen and pay attention
clearly 'kliəli POS: adv	adv. 清楚地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. without doubt or question; r. in an easily perceptible manner
everybody 'evribɒdi POS: pron	pron. 每个人, 人人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. Every person.
easily 'i:zili POS: adv	adv. 容易地, 轻易地, 流利地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. with ease ('easy' is sometimes used informally for 'easily'); r. without question
interesting 'intrɪstɪŋ POS: a	a. 有趣的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. arousing or holding the attention
excellent 'eksələnt POS: a	a. 优良的, 杰出的, 出色的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. very good; of the highest quality
definitely 'defɪnɪtli POS: adv	adv. 明确无疑地, 清楚地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r without question and beyond doubt
dominate 'domɪneɪt POS: v	v. 支配, 占优势 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. be in control; v. have dominance or the power to defeat over; v. look down on
slight slaɪt POS: n	n. 轻蔑, 怠慢; a. 轻微的, 纤细的, 脆弱的, 苗条的; vt. 轻视, 忽略, 怠慢 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. pay no attention to, disrespect
hello hə'ləu POS: review required	interj. 喂, 嘿 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an expression of greeting
distinguish dɪ'stɪŋɡwɪʃ POS: v	v. 区别, 辨别 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. mark as different; v. be a distinctive feature, attribute, or trait; sometimes in a very positive sense
owe əu POS: vt	vt. 亏欠, 负...债, 归功于, 怀有, 应给予, 感恩; vi. 欠钱 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. be obliged to pay or repay; v. be indebted to, in an abstract or intellectual sense; v. be in debt
literally 'lɪərəli POS: adv	adv. 逐字地, 按照字面上地, 不夸张地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. in a literal sense; r. (intensifier before a figurative expression) without exaggeration
undoubtedly ʌn'daɪtɪdli POS: adv	adv. 无疑, 必定, 确实地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. without doubt; certainly
admire əd'maɪə POS: vt	vt. 赞美, 钦佩, 爱慕; vi. 称赞, 惊奇 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. feel admiration for; v. look at with admiration
distinctive dɪ'stɪŋktɪv POS: a	a. 有特色的, 出众的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. of a feature that helps to distinguish a person or thing
superb sju'pə:b POS: a	a. 极度的, 华丽的, 极好的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. surpassingly good
mainstream 'meɪnstri:m POS: n	n. 主流 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the prevailing current of thought
firstly 'fɜ:stli POS: adv	adv. 第一, 首先 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r before anything else
supervision ,sju:pə'vɪʒən POS: n	n. 监督, 管理; [经] 监督, 管理 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. management by overseeing the performance or operation of a person or group
fisherman 'fɪʃmə:n POS: n	n. 渔夫, 钓鱼者, 渔船 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone whose occupation is catching fish
inspect ɪn'spekt POS: vt	vt. 检查, 检阅, 检验; vi. 检查 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. look over carefully
beast bi:st POS: n	n. 畜生, 动物, 野兽, 兽性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a cruelly rapacious person

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
distract dis'trækt POS: vt	vt. 转移, 分心, 使发狂 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. draw someone's attention away from something
deliberate di'libəreɪt POS: a	a. 深思熟虑的, 故意的, 从容的; v. 仔细考虑 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. carefully thought out in advance
utterly 'ʌtəli POS: adv	adv. 完全地, 全然, 绝对 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r completely and without qualification; used informally as intensifiers
sofa 'səʊfə POS: n	n. 沙发 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an upholstered seat for more than one person
foolish 'fu:liʃ POS: a	a. 愚蠢的, 傻的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. devoid of good sense or judgment
scar ska: POS: n	n. 疤痕, 伤痕, 悬崖; vi. 结疤, 愈合, 痊愈; vt. 使有伤痕 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a mark left (usually on the skin) by the healing of injured tissue; v. mark with a scar
insure in'ʃʊə POS: vt	vt. 保险, 确保; vi. 投保 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. take out insurance for
parenting 'peərəntɪŋ POS: n	n. 父母对子女的养育 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v bring up
preacher 'pri:tʃə POS: n	n. 传道士, 讲道者, 牧师 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone whose occupation is preaching the gospel
lick lik POS: n	n. 舔, 少许, 打; vt. 舔, 卷过, 鞭打; vi. 轻轻拍打 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. touching with the tongue; v. pass the tongue over
invaluable in'væljuəbl POS: a	a. 无价的, 价值无法衡量的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. having incalculable monetary, intellectual, or spiritual worth
tasty 'teisti POS: a	a. 好吃的, 可口的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. pleasing to the sense of taste
witty 'witi POS: a	a. 富于机智的, 诙谐的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. combining clever conception and facetious expression
idiom 'idiəm POS: n	n. 习语, 成语, 惯用语, 方言 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an expression whose meanings cannot be inferred from the meanings of the words that make it up
expend ik'spend POS: vt	vt. 花费, 消耗, 用光 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v use up, consume fully; v pay out
figurative 'figjʊrətɪv POS: a	a. 比喻的, 象征的, 修饰丰富的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. (used of the meanings of words or text) not literal; using figures of speech
priceless 'praɪslɪs POS: a	a. 无价的, 极贵重的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s having incalculable monetary, intellectual, or spiritual worth
sightseeing 'saɪtsi:ɪŋ POS: n	n. 观光, 游览; a. 观光的, 游览的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. going about to look at places of interest
underdeveloped ˌʌndə'deɪvələpt POS: a	a. 开发不充分的, 不发达的, 发育不全的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. not yet fully developed
beautify 'bju:tɪfaɪ POS: vt	vt. 美化, 变美, 修饰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v make more beautiful; v be beautiful to look at; v make more attractive by adding ornament, colour, etc.
attributive ə'trɪbjʊ:tɪv POS: a	a. 归属的, 属性的, 定语; n. 定语 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of adjectives; placed before the nouns they modify